

Most “internship abroad” lists count student visas. Only a handful of countries run a **real work authorisation an employer can sponsor you onto** — and the two biggest that are open to any nationality issue about **33,000 places a year between them**, down a third from 2019. The larger schemes are bigger precisely because they are closed: they run on bilateral treaties that most of Africa and South Asia are not party to.

P<NGAINTERNSHIP<<SPONSORSHIP<ROUTE<AUDIT<<<<<<<<<<<<<
J1<GAE<16E<407<IEC<TEP<D101<<OPEN4<<GATED4<<2026<<<<<<

Ranked by verified annual headcount. These routes gate on an employer or a designated sponsor organisation accepting you – nothing in the rules excludes a Nigerian, Indian or Filipino applicant.

USA · **J-1** INTERN + TRAINEE

United States

Exchange Visitor Program, via ~96 State-Dept-designated sponsors

25,482

CY2025 · UNCAPPED

16,877 INTERN / 8,605 TRAINEE

The only genuinely large open route on earth. **Intern:** currently enrolled, or graduated within 12 months. **Trainee:** degree + 1 year related experience, *or* 5 years experience with no degree — the clause that makes this reachable for self-taught engineers. 12 months (18 for hospitality/agriculture). You pay a sponsor like Cultural Vistas, CIEE or Intrax to issue the DS-2019.

GBR · **GAE** TEMPORARY WORK

United Kingdom

Government Authorised Exchange, via approved overarching bodies

7,378

YR TO JUN 2026 · UNCAPPED

3.1% OF ALL UK WORK VISAS

Work experience, training or research for 12–24 months. Not sponsored by the employer directly — an approved **overarching body** runs the scheme and holds the licence, which is the real bottleneck. Top senders: France 1,267, US 1,056, China 1,043, India 217.

DEU · **§16e** / **§16a** AufenthG

Germany

Study-related internship & vocational training permits

Not published

UNCAPPED · CONSENT OF THE

BUNDESAGENTUR FÜR ARBEIT

Germany does not break internships out of its migration statistics, so no headcount can be quoted honestly. What is measurable is the **onward path**, which is the best of any country here: 7,385 EU Blue Cards issued as first permits in H1 2025 alone, plus the Opportunity Card (Chancenkarte) for job-seeking. §16e caps at 6 months; treat it as an entry ramp, not a destination.

AUS · **407** TRAINING VISA

Australia

Employer-nominated occupational training, up to 2 years

Volatile

UNCAPPED · BUT 55% REFUSED
OR WITHDRAWN, FY25-26

Lodgements jumped 360% in FY2024-25 and Home Affairs responded with an integrity crackdown. **More than half of all applications now fail.** Structurally open and genuinely employer-sponsored, but the expected value right now is poor — do not make it your primary plan.

SGP · **TEP** TRAINING EMPLOYMENT PASS

Singapore

Short training stint, exempt from quota and levy

Uncapped

MAX 3 MONTHS
S\$3,000/MO THRESHOLD

Fast and genuinely open — no nationality gate, no foreign-worker quota, no levy. The catch is duration: **three months**, which suits a summer placement and nothing longer. Requires either an acceptable institution or the salary floor.

KOR · **D-10-1** JOB SEEKER

South Korea

Job-seeking status that permits paid internships

Uncapped

RULES LOOSENED 29 OCT 2025
1 YR PER FIRM · 3 YR TOTAL STAY

The most improved route of the last year. Since October 2025 a D-10 holder can intern at one company for a **full year with no cap on total internship time**, and the visa itself now extends to three years. You enter on your own initiative rather than waiting for a sponsor.

Ireland

Plus the Atypical Working Scheme for <90-day placements

Marginal

CONTEXT: 26,629 PERMITS

ISSUED JAN-AUG 2026, ALL TYPES

Exists, but narrow: you must be studying **outside** Ireland in a field on the critical-skills list, and the internship must be integral to your degree. Unpaid placements are excluded outright. Ireland's real door for Africans is the general permit system — Nigeria took 567 permits in eight months of 2026, South Africa 1,002, Zimbabwe 783.

Netherlands & Japan

Trainee (IND recognised sponsor) · Designated Activities

Conditional

REQUIRES CURRENT ENROLMENT

OR A <2-YR-OLD DEGREE

Both technically sponsor interns, both effectively require you to already be a student. The Netherlands needs an IND-recognised sponsor plus study abroad at mbo/hbo/university level or graduation within two years; Japan requires a **formal agreement between your university and the host company**. Neither works for an unenrolled applicant.

Bigger — and closed to you

PASSPORT DECIDES

These are the schemes that produce the impressive numbers people cite. Every one runs on bilateral reciprocity: your country must have signed a treaty. No African country participates in any of them except Switzerland's, and South Asia only via the UK.

Canada

International Experience Canada, internship stream

61,189

2026 SEASON QUOTA,

ALL THREE IEC CATEGORIES

Needs a signed job offer before arrival, then a randomised lottery against a per-country quota (UK 9,285; Australia 5,670). **36 partner countries — none in Africa.**

| NGA · GHA · KEN · IND · PAK · PHL — not eligible

GBR · **YMS** YOUTH MOBILITY

United Kingdom

2-year open work permission, no employer needed

20,323

YR TO JUN 2026 · 13 COUNTRIES

76,100+ PLACES OFFERED

Nearly 3× the size of GAE and far better terms — you work for anyone, no sponsor at all. Australia 7,728, Canada 3,063, NZ 2,965, India 2,367 (ballot), Japan 1,899, Korea 1,256.

| **Africa: no participating country**

CHE · **YOUNG PROFESSIONALS**

Switzerland

Bilateral trainee (“stagiaires”) agreements, 18 months

~14 treaties

AGES 18–35 · DEGREE OR

2-YR APPRENTICESHIP REQUIRED

The one gated scheme with a southern-hemisphere and African door: **South Africa, Tunisia, Indonesia and the Philippines** all hold treaties, alongside Argentina, Chile, Japan, Canada and the US. Small volumes, 18-month permits, capped at 5% of a firm's headcount.

SGP · **WHP** WORK HOLIDAY PASS

Singapore

Six-month work-and-holiday for students and graduates

2,000

CONCURRENT CAP

10 COUNTRIES, AGES 18–25

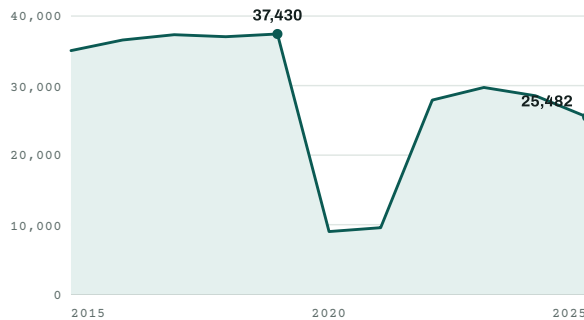
Tiny, and restricted to ten wealthy countries and territories. Listed only so the comparison is complete — if you are eligible for this you were already eligible for better.

The open market is shrinking

Both open routes peaked before COVID and neither has recovered. This is the single most important trend for anyone planning around them: you are competing for fewer places than the guides assume.

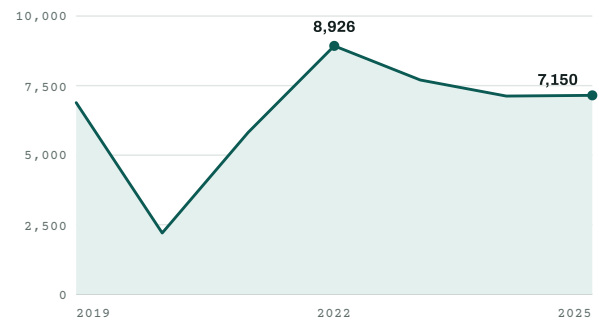
United States — J-1 intern + trainee

Placements per calendar year. 2025 sits 31.9% below the 2019 peak.



United Kingdom — GAE grants

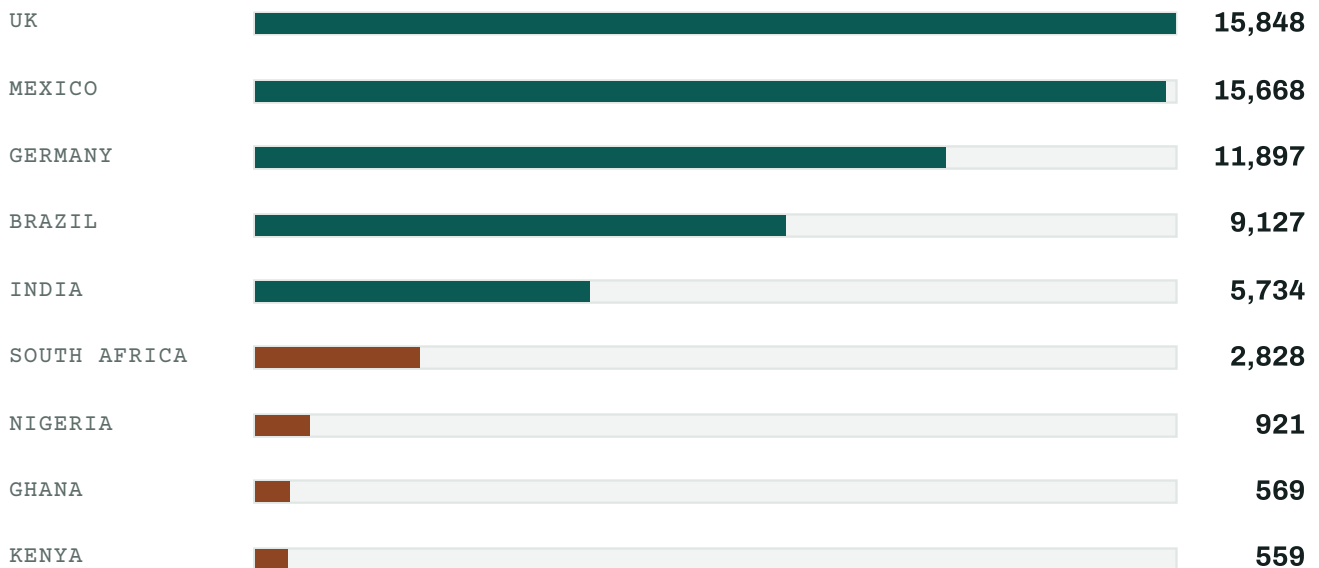
Visas issued per calendar year. Flat near 7,100 for three years running.



Headcount is not access

What a Nigerian passport actually collects from these schemes

The J-1 programme placed 275,000 people in 2025. Nigeria took 921 of them — 0.33%, across every category including au pairs and camp counsellors. The UK's GAE route issued 7,378 visas; Nigeria took 57.



This is not a rule written anywhere — it is a recruiting artefact. Designated sponsor organisations run offices and partner networks in Europe and Latin America, and consular refusal risk under §214(b) is treated as higher for African applicants. The route is legally open and practically thin, which means the constraint you are optimising against is sponsor reach and visa-interview risk, not eligibility.

How I'd play it

Given the data above and a software background, in priority order.

PLAY 01

J-1 Trainee, not J-1 Intern

Same programme, better clause. The **Trainee** category accepts five years of relevant experience with no degree at all, or a degree plus one year — and it runs 18 months where the intern route runs 12. Apply through a designated sponsor directly (Cultural Vistas, CIEE, Intrax) rather than hunting job boards; the sponsor, not the employer, is the gate.

PLAY 02

Germany for the exit, not the entry

§16e caps at six months and Germany publishes no intern headcount, so judge it on where it leads instead: the EU Blue Card at 7,385 first issuances in half a year, and the Opportunity Card as a job-seeking bridge. **No other country on this list converts a short placement into permanent status this readily.** Tech salary thresholds for the Blue Card are set lower than for other professions.

PLAY 03

South Korea's D-10 is the sleeper

The October 2025 rule change turned a job-seeker visa into an uncapped internship visa: one year per company, three years of total stay, and **you initiate it yourself** instead of waiting for an employer to sponsor. No nationality gate, no lottery, no overarching body. The trade is language and a smaller English-speaking tech market.

PLAY 04

Skip Australia 407 this cycle

A 55% refusal-and-withdrawal rate makes it the worst expected value on the board despite being structurally open. Revisit after Home Affairs finishes its integrity review — the route is sound, the current processing posture is not.

PLAY 05

Don't spend effort on the gated tier

Canada IEC, UK Youth Mobility and Singapore's WHP together hold more places than every open route combined, and no amount of a strong CV changes a treaty. **The one exception worth checking is Switzerland**, whose young-professionals agreements do include South Africa, Tunisia, Indonesia and the Philippines.

METHOD, DEFINITIONS AND KNOWN GAPS

- **“Sponsored”** here means a work authorisation an employer or designated body applies for on your behalf. Student visas with side-work rights, and Erasmus+ traineeships (EU students only), are excluded — that exclusion is what shrinks the list from forty countries to about a dozen.
- **US figures** are participant counts by programme-begin year from the State Department's own participation workbook (CY2015–2025), not visa issuances — a participant may hold a visa issued the prior year.
- **UK figures** are visas issued, aggregated from the Home Office entry-clearance outcomes dataset to 2026 Q2, filtered to outcome = *Issued*. The 12-month window is 2025 Q3 – 2026 Q2; calendar-year series are separate.
- **The 32,860 open-route total** is J-1 intern + trainee (25,482) plus UK GAE (7,378). It deliberately excludes Germany, Australia, Singapore, Korea, Ireland, the Netherlands and Japan, none of which publish an intern-specific count — so the true open-route figure is somewhat higher than 32,860, not lower.
- **The 81,512 gated total** is Canada IEC (61,189), UK YMS (20,323) and Singapore WHP (2,000). Canada's is a quota, the UK's is actual issuances.

WHERE THIS ANALYSIS IS WEAKEST

Germany, the Netherlands and Japan almost certainly place meaningful numbers of interns, but none of the three separates internships from broader education or employment migration in published statistics. Australia's Home Affairs 407 review reports percentage changes without absolute grant counts. Any ranking that gives you precise headcounts for those four is inventing them.